

Your HomeGuard™ Starter Guide

A quick, no-pressure reference for Maryland and DC homeowners — how to hire honest contractors, avoid the most common repair scams, and keep your home maintained. Keep this handy before you sign or pay for any work.

1. Vet Any Contractor Before You Pay a Dime

- ✓ **Verify the license** — confirm the Maryland MHIC number is active on the MD Dept. of Labor site (DCRA for DC).
- ✓ **Proof of insurance** — ask for a current certificate showing general liability (and workers' comp if they have a crew).
- ✓ **Two recent local references** — actually call them; ask “would you hire them again without hesitating?”
- ✓ **Written, itemized contract** — scope, materials, start/finish dates, total price, payment schedule.
- ✓ **Tie payments to milestones**, never to the calendar; keep a meaningful final payment until after your walkthrough.

2. Seven Red Flags a Contractor May Be a Scam

- ✓ Shows up uninvited, especially right after a storm.
- ✓ Pressures you to decide or pay **today** to “lock in a price.”
- ✓ Demands a large cash deposit up front.
- ✓ No verifiable local address or active license.
- ✓ Quote is vague, verbal, or “we’ll sort the details later.”
- ✓ Asks you to sign an **Assignment of Benefits (AOB)** handing over your insurance rights.
- ✓ Discourages you from calling your own insurer first.

3. After a Storm — Stay in Control

- ✓ No same-day roof access for anyone who knocked uninvited.
- ✓ Take your own dated photos before any contractor “finds” damage.
- ✓ Call **your insurer** first — not the contractor.
- ✓ Get three estimates from established local companies; choose the middle one.
- ✓ Never sign an AOB form.

4. Keep-These-Handy Checklist

- ✓ Your insurance claims phone number and policy number.

- ✓ Three pre-vetted local contractors (licenses already verified).
- ✓ Bookmark: Maryland MHIC license lookup.
- ✓ Location of your main water shutoff and electrical panel.
- ✓ Dated photos of your roof and exterior (refresh each spring & fall).

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